

The Passing of a Titan



Ratan Tata was many things to many people, depending on whom he came in contact with. A visionary business leader and bold entrepreneur who felt strongly about India and its growth ambition, the passing away of Ratan Naval Tata at the age of 86 has left a void in Indian business that will be almost impossible to fill. If there was one thing Ratan Tata embodied throughout his decades-long career, it was integrity. The world of business is often fraught with challenges and pitfalls, but Ratan Tata always conducted himself with utmost civility and kept ethics and integrity uppermost in his actions. In every sense, then, Ratan Tata was the perfect ambassador of the group he led, a storied conglomerate respected the world over for its ethics and values.

As the country mourns its Ratan, we bring you what the legacy of Ratan Tata is, and what his passing means for India Inc. Ratan Tata was a role model for all entrepreneurs, big and small, for a variety of reasons. He was kind but firm on occasion, cautious but also a risk-taker when needed. Those following his career will remember well how, early enough in his innings at the helm of the Tata group, he managed to tame the powerful 'satraps' who led various group companies, and ensured his vision for the group was executed. He groomed several leaders within the group, including Natarajan Chandrasekaran who now helms the \$165-billion conglomerate efficiently, taking forward the Tata legacy of creating value. Whether it was the acquisition of tea major Tetley in 2000, the launch of the Tata Indica when everyone was betting against it, the bold acquisition of global car major Jaguar Land Rover, or steelmaker Corus, Ratan Tata went by his instinct when required and had the perseverance to follow through. The launch of the controversial Nano was another such instance. Grit and gumption are key hallmarks of a successful entrepreneur and Ratan Tata had oodles of it. A curious mind, Ratan Tata was also in step with the times and invested in several start-ups as India's ecosystem grew in size and scale. A passionate flyer, he was also overjoyed when the group brought home national carrier Air India in January 2022.

The results of Ratan Tata's leadership and vision were there for all to see. During his chairmanship from 1991 to 2012, the group transformed into a giant with a deep global footprint, with investors celebrating it and market capitalisation growing multiple times. Today, the Tata group has a market capitalisation of around ₹33 lakh crore, or over \$400 billion and the group has much to thank Ratan Tata for. A well-known animal lover and a philanthropist in the finest Tata tradition, Ratan Tata leaves behind a legion of followers—Tata group employees, entrepreneurs, business leaders, politicians and ordinary Indians. A jewel is gone. All eyes will now be on Noel Tata, who has been appointed the Chairman of Tata Trusts, which controls 66% of Tata Sons, the group's holding company. The Ratan Tata legacy will have to be taken forward. **BT**

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